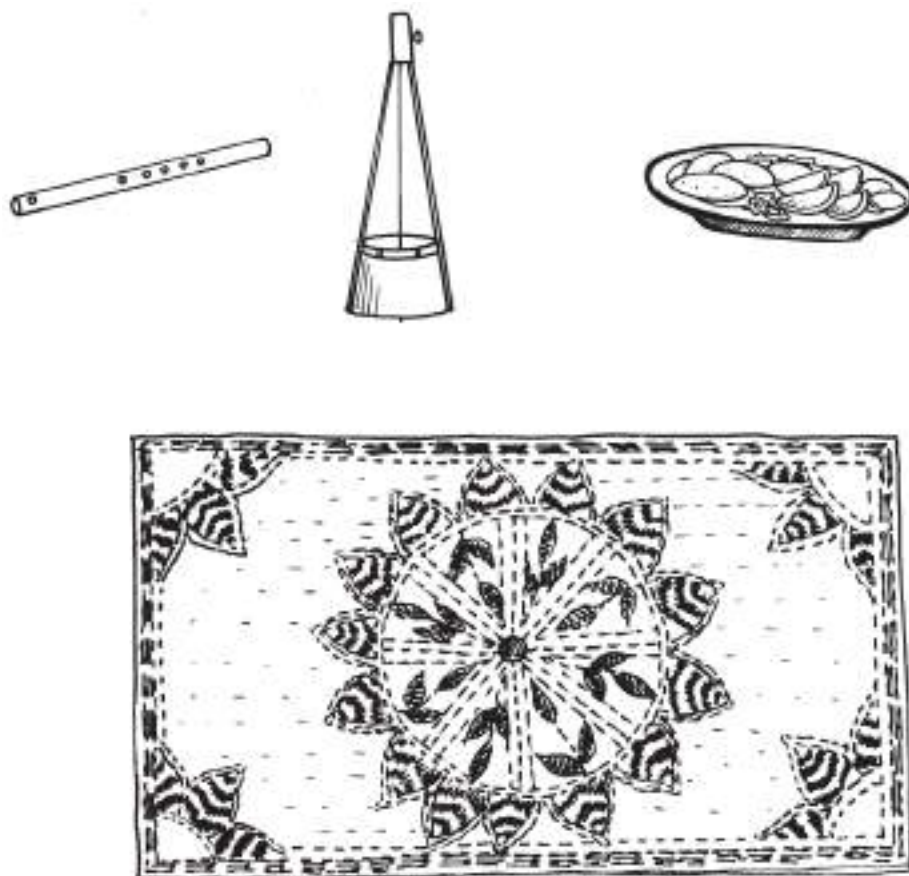


Unit One

A Glimpse of Our Culture



After we have studied this unit, we will be able to

- read and understand texts through silent reading
- infer meaning from context
- ask and answer questions
- write answers to questions
- write short compositions

Lesson 1: Folk Song



A set of four stamps issued on 21 July 2011 on Traditional Musical Instruments of Bangladesh

Keywords:

people's music, oral tradition, self-expression, instruments, migration

A. Work in Pairs:

1. What kinds of music do you listen to in your daily life? Are they related to your family traditions or culture?
2. How do you think music changes over time? Does it stay the same, or does it evolve with people's lifestyles?
3. Can you think of any traditional instruments you've seen or heard about? What materials do you think they're made from?
4. Why might certain types of music become less common as people move from villages to cities?

B. Read the text and answer the following questions:

People's music, also known as folk music, consists of tunes, lyrics, and knowledge passed down orally for generations. Over time, this music has evolved, closely tied to the way people live. Our agriculture, food, ecology, seasons, and rituals are all reflected in these songs. Palligiti, Bhatiwali, Jari, Sari,

Gambhira, Lalon Giti, Paalagan, and the songs of Hason Raja all embody the self-expression of the people.

As the landscape changes, the music shifts too. In the hill tracts, you encounter music with the same role but expressed in the diverse languages of the ethnic communities. The instruments used for folk music are crafted from materials found in the surroundings—animal skin, bamboo, and calabash are common examples. The sounds they produce are deeply connected to the land they come from. As people migrate to cities and villages transform, these traditional tunes are slowly fading. However, folk music still finds its place in mainstream films and music albums.

The following are translations of a Hason Raja song and a Bhawaiya song featured in the film *Asiya*, directed by Fateh Lohani:

Translation of Hason Raja's song “Loke Bole Bole Re (Oh, They Say)”

*Oh, They say my house is no good,
But what can I build with nothing here?
I'll erect a home,
Yet how long will I truly stay?
I gaze into the mirror,
Noticing the strands of grey in my hair.
Thinking of this,
Hason Raja never built a dwelling.
Where will Allah take him? Where will he find rest?
This uncertainty brings him to tears.
If only Hason Raja had known his days,
He would have painted his rooms in vibrant hues.
Oh, They say my house is no good,
But what can I build with nothing here?*

Listen to the Bhawaiya song on the internet as featured in the film *Asiya* and sung by Mustafa Zaman Abbasi and Ferdousi Rahman:

Questions:

1. What are some examples of Bangladeshi folk music genres mentioned in the passage?
2. How are the instruments used in folk music connected to the land and environment?
3. What happens to folk music as people move to cities and villages change?
4. How is Bangladeshi folk music still present in mainstream media, despite its decline?

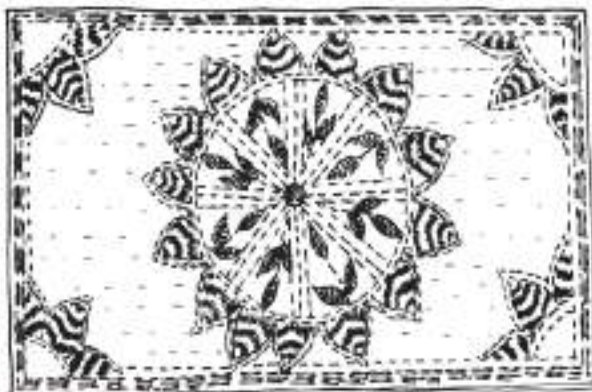
C. Discuss in groups and write a paragraph on the following topic:

How has Bangladeshi folk music changed over the years, and what is its importance in everyday life and culture today?

- D.** The following sentences describe the life of Hason Raja but are not in the correct order. Rearrange them to form a meaningful passage.
- His unique style of music filled with emotion and devotion made him one of the most prominent figures in Bengali folk culture.
 - He was born on 21st December 1854 in Teghoriya village of Lakshmiansree Parghana, now Sunamganj to a Bengali Muslim zaminder family.
 - He established schools and religious centres like mosques and he is said to have been widely engaged in charities within his immediate communities.
 - Raja's songs are collected in books Hason Udas and Shaukhin Bahar.
 - Dewan Hason Raja Chowdhury, simply known as Hason Raja, who was Bengali mystic poet and song writer.
 - Today, a museum in Sylhet is dedicated to preserving his memory and contributions.
 - Hason Raja died on 6 December 1922.
 - Despite his riches, he felt a deep connection with the common people.

Lesson 2: Nakshi Kantha

Keywords: quilt, artistic, commercially, traditional, demand, pattern



A. Look at the picture and the questions. Then ask and answer the questions with your partner:

1. What do you see in the picture?
2. What is it called?
3. Have you seen it before? Where?
4. What do we do with it?

B. Excerpt from 'The Field of the Embroidered Quilt' (Nokshi Kanthar Math) by Jasimuddin:

Spreading the embroidered quilt,
 She works the livelong night,
 As if her poet were
 On his bereaved plight.
 Many a joy and many a sorrow
 Is written on her breast;
 The story of Rupai's life is there,
 Line by line expressed.
 "How will he bear the pain, mother?
 On this quilt lies all of mine—
 All my pain and my grief,
 Embroidered line by line.
 So lay it on my grave, mother.
 This picture of my grief,
 That his and mine upon its breast
 May mingling find relief.

Translation: E. M. Milford

C. Now, read the text to know about Nakshi Kantha:

Nakshi Kantha is a kind of embroidered quilt. The name was taken from the Bangla word, '*naksha*' which means artistic pattern. It is a kind of traditional craft and is said to be indigenous to Bangladesh and West Bengal in India. The art has been practised in rural Bangladesh for centuries. The name *Nakshi Kantha* became popular after the poet Jasimuddin's poem '*Nakshi Kanthar Math*' was published in 1929.

Traditional *kanthas* are made for family use. Old or new cloth and thread are used to make these quilts. Mymensingh, Jamalpur, Rajshahi, Faridpur, Bogura and Jashore are most famous for this craft. Now, it is produced commercially. You can find them in many expensive handicraft shops in cities. The quilts are now in great demand because of the colourful patterns and designs embroidered on them.

D. Complete the sentences with clues given. There are more words than necessary:

bengali	patterns	embroidery	years	fashion	art	rural	designs	quilt	<i>naksha</i>
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1. *Naksha* means artistic
2. The name was taken from a word
3. The art has been practised in Bengal for
4. *Nakshi Kanthas* are now sold in shops.
5. *Nakshi Kanthas* are in great demand because of their colourful and
6. *Nakshi Kanthas* are a kind of

E. Write down five questions for the completed statements in Activity D above:

One is done for you.

1. What does *naksha* mean ?

F. Do you like a *Nakshi Kantha* or an ordinary *kantha*? Why?

G. Work in pairs. Ask and answer all the questions that you have written in Activity E. Now, write 3-4 more questions on the text given in Activity B above:

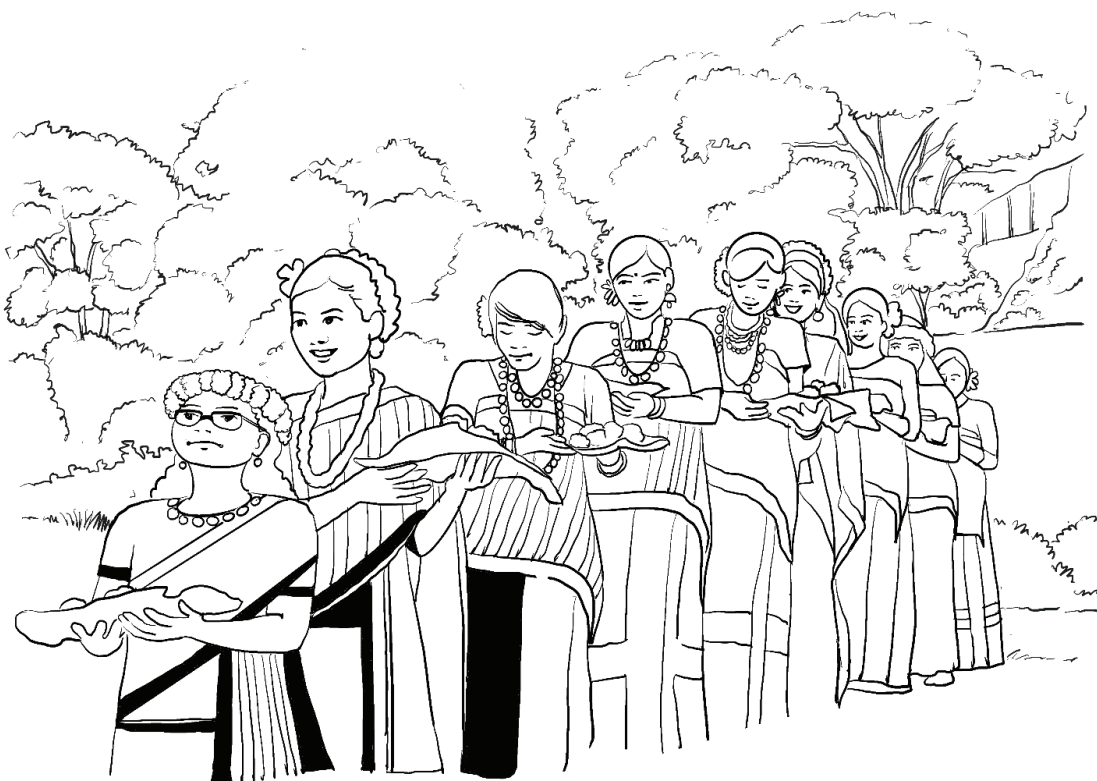
**H. Write a paragraph describing how the *Nakshi Kantha* is made. Start like this:
Old or new cloth and coloured thread are needed. First, the cloth is folded, then**

Lesson 3: Our Ethnic Communities

Keywords: ethnic, flatlands, distinct, urbanisation, legacy, hurdles, livelihood

A. Look at the picture and discuss the following questions in pairs:

1. What do you see in the picture?
2. What are the women carrying in their hands?
3. Why are they standing in line?



B. Now, read the text and complete the following activities:

Bangladesh is home to more than 50 small ethnic groups, including the Chakma, Marma, and Tripura. While most of them live in the northern and southeastern flatlands, others reside in the Chittagong Hill Tracts. Each group has its distinct lifestyles, economic practices, and belief systems. Moreover, these communities speak at least 35 distinct languages, adding to the country's cultural richness. However, many of these languages are now endangered owing to a variety of reasons including urbanisation, modernisation and migration. This global issue is known as "language death." In fact, the UN warns that many ethnic languages are disappearing at an alarming rate, with one language dying every two weeks.

During the British colonial rule, ethnic minority groups played a significant role in resisting oppression. Leaders like Sidhu and Kanu led uprisings such as the Santhal Rebellion, thereby highlighting their contributions to the anti-colonial struggle. However, despite this legacy, ethnic minority communities in Bangladesh today face challenges in preserving their languages and cultural

heritage. Although the government is providing continuous efforts to include ethnic people's languages in pre-primary and primary education, these efforts are facing hurdles like shortage of trained teachers and adequate resources for higher education in these languages.

Furthermore, due to the construction of Kaptai Dam in 1957, the people living at the surrounding areas were relocated to areas far from their homes and farmlands. It, consequently, had a far reaching impact on their life and livelihood.

C. True or False? If False, give the correct information:

1. The ethnic people of our country live in the Chittagong Hill Tracts only.
2. They speak in only one language.
3. Ethnic minority groups played vital role against British colonial rule.
4. Bangladesh government is providing efforts to preserve their languages.
5. There are adequate trained teachers and sufficient resources for higher education in ethnic languages.

D. Complete the text using words from the box.

struggle	heritage	teachers	diversity	formal
rebellion	rights	oppression	language	resources

At the time of the British colonial rule, ethnic minority groups played an important role in resisting _____. Leaders like Sidhu and Kanu led uprisings such as the Santhal _____. These efforts represent their contribution to the anti-colonial _____. Today, ethnic communities are encountering problems in keeping their _____ and cultural _____ alive. The government is trying to include their languages in _____ education. But there is a lack of trained _____ and enough _____ for higher education. More support is needed to protect their _____ and cultural _____.

E. Suppose you are Sajeed and you have a Marma friend named Ei Mon. Now, write a dialogue asking and answering questions about your dress, food, culture and pastimes.

Lesson 4 : Bangladeshi Cuisine

A. Look at the pictures and answer the following questions:



1. What do you see in the pictures?
2. Which foods are seen in the pictures? Do you prepare/eat them at home?
3. Among the foods, which one is your favourite? Why?

B. Read the text below and answer the following True-False Activity in section C:

Bangladeshi cuisine is rich and varied with the use of many spices. We have delicious and appetizing food, snacks and sweets.

Boiled rice is our staple food. It is served with a variety of vegetables, curry, lentil soups, fish and meat. Fish is the main source of protein. Fish are now cultivated in ponds. Also we have fresh-water fish in the lakes and rivers. More than 40 types of fish are common. Some of them are *carp*, *ruhi*, *katla*, *magur* (catfish), *chingri* (prawn or shrimp). *Hilsha* is very popular among the people of Bangladesh. Dried fish or *shutki* is also popular.

Panta ilish is a popular traditional platter. It is steamed rice soaked in water and served with a fried hilsha slice, often together with dried fish, pickles, lentil soup, green chilies and onion. It is a popular dish on the Pohela Boishakh.

The people of Bangladesh are very fond of sweets. Almost all Bangladeshi women prepare some traditional sweets. Pitha, a type of cakes made from rice flour, sugar, syrup, molasses and sometimes milk, is a traditional food loved by the entire population. During winter *Pitha Utsab*, meaning *pitha* festival, is organized by different groups of people.

Sweets are distributed among close relatives when there is good news like births, weddings, promotions, etc.

Sweets of Bangladesh are mostly milk-based. The common ones are *roshogolla*, *shondesh*, *roshmalai*, *gulab jam*, *kalo jam* and *chomchom*. There are hundreds of different varieties of sweet preparations. Sweets are therefore an important part of the day-to-day life of Bangladeshi people.

C. True or False? If False, give the correct information:

1. Our food is rich because it has a lot of oil in them.
2. We get protein mostly from fish.
3. On *Pohela Boishakh*, the traditional food is steamed rice and fried *hilsha*.
4. *Pitha Uthsab* takes place almost all the year round in Bangladesh.
5. Sweets are not much appreciated by the people of Bangladesh.

D. Discuss and answer the questions in pairs:

1. Describe a Bangladeshi food item that you like best.
2. Make a list of the things you and your partner eat every day.
3. Make two lists of food items, one eaten by the urban people and the other by the rural people.
4. Why are there differences between the food eaten by the urban people and the food eaten by the rural people?

E. Read the text in B again and answer the following questions:

1. What has made Bangladeshi food so special?
2. Where do we get the fish from?

3. Apart from fish, what other foods do we eat with rice?
4. Why are sweets an important part of our life?

F. How fast can you say this sentence?

Casual clothes are provisional for leisurely trips across Asia.

Lesson 5: The Children's Songs

A. Read and recite the poem:

The Children's Songs

Land of our Birth, we pledge to thee
Our love and toil in the years to be;
When we are grown and take our place
As men and women of our race.

Father in Heaven, Who lovest all,
Oh, help Thy children when they call;
That they may build from age to age,
An undefiled heritage.

Teach us to bear the yoke in youth,
With steadfastness and careful truth;
That, in our time, Thy Grace may give
The Truth whereby the Nations live.

Teach us to rule ourselves always,
Controlled and cleanly night and day;
That we may bring, if need arise,
No maimed and worthless sacrifice.

Teach us to look in all our ends,
On Thee for judge, and not our friends;
That we, with Thee, may walk uncowed
By fear or favour of the crowd.

Teach us the strength that cannot seek,
By deed or thought, to hurt the weak;
That, under Thee, we may possess
Man's strength to comfort man's distress.

Teach us Delight in simple things,
And Mirth that had no bitter springs;
Forgiveness free of evil done,
And Love to all men, 'neath the sun!

Land of our Birth, our faith, our pride,
 For whose dear sake our fathers died;
 Oh, Motherland, we pledge to thee
 Head, heart and hand through the years to be!

- Rudyard Kipling

Word notes :

pledge : make a promise

toll : hard work

lovest : love

thy : your

undefiled : pure

heritage : the history, traditions, buildings and qualities that a country has had for many years and that are an important part of the country's character

yoke : a piece of wood that holds two oxen together, while ploughing or pulling a cart

bear the yoke : shoulder the great responsibility

B. Read the poem silently and answer the questions:

1. What do the children ask for in their prayer?
2. Why do the children pray for their country's future?
3. What does the line "Teach us Delight in simple things" suggest?
4. What do the children promise to their motherland?
5. What do the children ask God to teach them?
6. Do you like the poem? Why?

C. Match the words from the poem with their correct meanings:

Word	Meaning
a) toil	i) uncorrupted, pure
b) heritage	ii) happiness and laughter
c) undefiled	iii) burden or responsibility
d) yoke	iv) hard work and effort
e) mirth	v) traditions and legacy passed down from ancestors